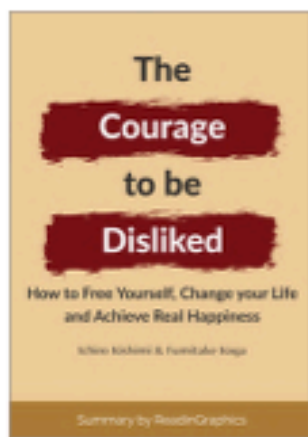




THE COURAGE TO BE DISLIKED

How to Free Yourself, Change your Life and Achieve Real Happiness

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The Big “So What”

The book answers the question “How can you achieve real happiness?” using insights from Adlerian psychology. The authors discuss concepts about self-acceptance, interpersonal relationships, personal growth, and personal freedom. They encourage readers to chart their own paths to find true happiness and fulfilment, even if it means breaking social norms and expectations.



Introduction



This book presents the key ideas and teachings of Austrian psychologist Alfred Adler, who founded “individual psychology.” Contrary to common belief, Adler’s philosophies differ from those of famous psychologists Sigmund Freud and Carl Jung. Adlerian psychology is more aligned with Greek philosophy and the teachings of Socrates, Plato, and Aristotle. Adler believed that happiness isn’t something that happens to you, but the result of how you choose to live your life. You’ll naturally find happiness if you develop yourself, build healthy interpersonal relationships, and contribute to your community.



There are 2 key behavioral objectives in Adlerian psychology:

- To be self-reliant as an individual. This requires the mindset “I have the ability (to create and steer my life).”
- To live in harmony with society. This requires the mindset “People are my comrades.”

KEY QUOTES

“Your life is not something that someone gives you, but something you choose yourself, and you are the one who decides how you live.”

Adlerian Psychology Overview

Goal: Be self-reliant as an individual.

Mindset: I have the ability (to shape my life).



The 2 Behavioral Goals and Mindsets



Goal: Live in harmony with society.

Mindset: People are my comrades.

KEY QUOTES



The authors dive into these ideas using a dialogue between a wise philosopher and a young man who's unhappy with life.

- Over 5 nights of intense debate, the young man learns many concepts around these 5 overlapping themes:
 - (i) Your past doesn't dictate your future.
 - (ii) To gain personal freedom, you must take responsibility for your life tasks, and let go of the need for external validation.
 - (iii) All problems come from interpersonal relationships. So, you must improve your relationships to improve your life.
 - (iv) The goal of relationships is to gain a sense of belonging, and you can only achieve this by contributing actively to your community.
 - (v) Live earnestly in the present moment to enjoy a fulfilling life.
- In this summary, we've distilled and organized these inter-related ideas into 3 main parts, presented in the next section.



Achieving Happiness & Fulfilment in Life



Your Past Does Not Dictate Your Future



According to Adler, there's no such thing as trauma. Painful experiences in the past cannot dictate your attitudes/actions unless you allow them to do so.

- The world is simple. It only seems complex because of our subjective perspectives. The same thing/event can be perceived differently by different people. For example, a glass of water at 15°C tastes cool to someone in the hot sun, but it tastes warm to someone in a freezing room.

"The world is simple and life is simple, too."

KEY QUOTES

*"We are not determined by our experiences, but the meaning we give them is self-determining."
—Alfred Adler*

"You are unable to change only because you are making the decision not to."

- We're not defined by our experiences, but by the meaning we give to those experiences. What happened in the past matters less than how we interpret and respond to those events.



That's the difference between etiology vs teleology.

- Etiology focuses how the past affects the present. This is the approach adopted by Sigmund Freud, who focuses on how past experiences, traumas, or psychic wounds impact our current thinking and behaviors.
- By contrast, teleology in Adlerian psychology ignores the past. It focuses on how our actions are driven by our current goals and motivations for the future.
 - Imagine a young man, Tom, who dares not step out of his room. The moment he does so, he starts to suffer from severe palpitations. From an etiological viewpoint, Tom probably suffered from some trauma in the past which led to his fear of going out. From a teleological viewpoint, Tom's past doesn't matter. He's not going out because he doesn't *want* to go out (possibly because he wants his parents' concern and attention). So, he works himself into a state of fear/anxiety to keep himself indoors.



Everyone experiences emotions, but we're not controlled by our emotions. Instead, we create and direct our emotions as part of our response to external situations.

- No one can "make" you angry. If you're angry, it's because you choose to use anger as a tool to achieve your goals.
 - (i) If a waiter spills soup on your favorite shirt and you start yelling at him, it's not because you've lost control of your anger. You've actually created the anger so you can yell at the waiter and get him to submit to you.
 - (ii) If you receive a call from your boss in the midst of a heated argument with your son, you'll probably switch to a calm tone to address your boss. Then, once you put the phone down, you start shouting at your son again. This shows that anger can be put away like a tool. You're just using it to manipulate the person/situation.
- Instead of blaming events/people for "making" you angry, take emotional responsibility by acknowledging that you choose to be angry.



Regardless of what happened in the past, everyone has the ability to change and shape their future.

- It's true that you cannot change what happened in the past. For example, if you were abused as a child, that's a fact. But, you can choose not to let those memories define and control you.
- Even your personality is not fixed, and you can change your dispositions. Adler uses the term "lifestyle" to describe how we tend to think and act. He argues that the way we see ourselves and the world are 2 sides of the same coin. For example, you can say "I'm an optimist" (personality) or "I have an optimistic view of the world" (viewpoint). The former sounds unchangeable, whereas the latter sounds malleable. By changing the lenses through which you view the world, you can start to see yourself and the world differently.



However, it takes courage to change and grow. Change is scary because it involves uncertainty. So, most people would rather complain about their circumstances and justify why they're helpless to change the status quo. They tell themselves, "I can only succeed if I'm like X" or "I'll be happy only if Y happens". These are merely their excuses for not changing.



Many people spend their lives being trapped by regrets about the past or anxieties about the future. A key to happiness is to focus fully on the here and now.

- You cannot change the past nor control the future. You can only accept the past, look forward to the future, and focus your energy on making the most of the present moment. Your choices and actions today will shape your future. So, use whatever you have right now to achieve your goals/desires.
- We tend to think of our lives like a storyline, from the time we're born until the time we die. We fabricate stories to string together the events in our lives. However, it's more accurate to think of life as a series of dots, each representing a moment. Your life is the sum of those moments. So long as you live each moment fully and earnestly, you'll have a rich and fulfilling life.
- If you're overly-focused on reaching a destination (e.g. earning \$1 million, becoming a famous actor), you'll treat everything

KEY QUOTES

*"The important thing is not what one is born with but what use one makes of that equipment."
—Alfred Adler*

"We do not lack ability. We just lack courage. It all comes down to courage."

"We cannot alter objective facts. But subjective interpretations can be altered as much as one likes. And we are inhabitants of a subjective world."

you do as a means to an end, to be completed as quickly as possible. If you fail to achieve the end-goal, your whole life seems like a failure. Even if you reach your goal, you may not be happy.

- Instead, live each moment like you're dancing. Realize that even if you die tomorrow, your life is complete as it is. Enjoy each moment fully, rather than see it as a step toward something else.



Gain Freedom through Personal Responsibility



Adlerian individual psychology is built on the concept of "holism," which says that each individual is a single, unified whole. You can't split your mind from your body, your conscious mind from your unconscious mind, nor your thoughts from your emotions. When you lose your temper and yell at someone, you're doing it as a whole person. Your emotions cannot "force" you to do it.



To be a member of society, you must perform 3 types of "life tasks". Fulfilling these tasks give you a sense of belonging and self-worth.

- Work tasks are the things you do as a part of your job, career, or contribution to society. Every person has the capacity to make a positive contribution.
- Social tasks relate to your relationships with other people outside of work, such as friendships or romantic relationships.
- Love tasks involve deep, intimate ties, such as those in love relationships or parent-child relationships. The closer the ties, the harder it is to build and maintain the relationship.



To enjoy personal freedom and happiness, you must take full responsibility for your life tasks, and leave others to theirs. Adler calls this the separation of tasks.

- Know where your task ends and where others' task begins.
 - (i) Ask: Whose task is this? Who will ultimately benefit from the task or decision?

KEY QUOTES

"If one is living each moment earnestly, there is no need to get too serious."

"We are not struck by emotions that somehow exist independently from us. Each of us is a unified whole."

(ii) You can only be responsible for your own thoughts, feelings, and behaviors. You cannot control others' thoughts, feelings, and actions, including whether they like or dislike you.

- Adopt the non-interference principle: don't interfere with other people's tasks, nor let others interfere with yours. This is not about being indifferent or aloof. It's about untangling the knots in a relationship to see things more clearly. Live according to your own values and principles, respect others' autonomy, and recognize the limits of your responsibility and influence. For example:

(i) If your parents oppose to your career choice, it's not your task to change jobs just to make them happy. Your task is to choose the path that you believe is right for you.

(ii) If you have an unreasonable boss who yells at you all day, it's not your task to make him like you, nor to satisfy his every whim. Your task is to do your job as best as you can, regardless of your boss's behavior.

(iii) Studying is a child's task since it affects his learning and future. If your child refuses to study, don't intervene by punishing him or forcing him to study. Instead, let your child know that it's his task to study, stay interested in what he's doing, and be ready to assist whenever he needs it.

 Task separation requires that you (i) stop living according to others' expectations, and (ii) stop demanding that others satisfy your expectations. This is hard to achieve because you must let go of the need for external validation.

- It feels good to be liked and recognized by others, and everyone likes to feel accepted and valued. But, if you're driven by the need for others' approval or recognition, you'll end up living someone else's life instead of your own. You may be tempted to do the wrong things just because no one is watching, or fail to do the right things because no one will notice.
- To achieve task separation, you need the courage to be disliked by others. You must also be honest with yourself: stop finding excuses to avoid your life tasks, blaming external factors or people for your unhappiness, lamenting about past injustices, or wishing for others to change.

KEY QUOTES

"What I should do is face my own tasks in my own life without lying."

"If you are not living your life for yourself, then who is going to live it for you?"

"All you can do with regard to your own life is to choose the best path that you believe in."

"Intervening in other people's tasks and taking on other people's tasks turns one's life into something heavy and full of hardship."

"People who are obsessed with...a desire for recognition will seem to be looking at other people, while they are actually looking only at themselves."

"Instead of waiting for others to change or waiting for the situation to change, you take the first step forward yourself."



Once you embrace task separation and release the need for recognition, you'll realize that you hold all the cards. Focus on the things you can do/change, rather than fret over things beyond your control. This will ultimately set you free and allow you to find true happiness.



Find Happiness by Contributing Actively to your Community



Human beings are social creatures. We get the greatest satisfaction and happiness when we feel like we belong and are making a positive contribution. Our well-being is closely tied to our relationships with others. In fact, Adler says that all problems are rooted in interpersonal relationships, since relationship problems will always spillover to other parts of our lives. When we improve our relationships, we naturally improve our lives.



Relationship problems are linked to our feelings of inferiority or a lack of self-worth.

- Feelings of inferiority aren't always negative. They can be a source of motivation to learn, improve, and strive for new heights, thus fueling healthy personal growth and improvement. Adler calls this the "pursuit of superiority."
- However, they can also lead to a defeatist attitude and a loss of courage if you develop an inferiority complex. This is when you tell yourself "I'm not good enough no matter what" or "Nothing I do will make a difference." Rather than overcome your shortcomings (e.g. a lack of skills or education), you use them as an excuse not to take action.
- Feelings of inferiority may also lead to a superiority complex, when people act as if they're better than others, and brag about their successes, their achievements, or even their misfortunes. They're actually trying to make themselves look/feel special to hide their insecurities. People who're truly confident about themselves won't feel the need to show off.
- Have the courage to be "normal". You don't need to be extraordinary to lead a fulfilling life. Rather than struggle endlessly to outdo others or prove your superiority, use what you already have to grow, contribute, and add value to others.

KEY QUOTES

"The courage to be happy also includes the courage to be disliked."

"All problems are interpersonal relationship problems."

"The pursuit of superiority and the feeling of inferiority are not diseases but stimulants to normal, healthy striving and growth."

"If one really has confidence in oneself, one doesn't feel the need to boast."

"Being normal is not being incapable. One does not need to flaunt one's superiority."



See others as comrades, not enemies/competitors. Many people are unhappy because they see the world through competitive lenses, and treat other people as rivals or enemies.

- In competitions, there are always winners and losers. It's hard to celebrate others' successes if you see them as signs of your own "defeat".
- Life is not a zero-sum game where your success must come at the expense of someone else's. When you see others as comrades, you can celebrate mutual progress/success, and enjoy the sense of camaraderie and connection. The more you contribute to others, the more value you see in yourself. This sense of purpose and self-worth is what brings you true happiness.
- You can improve yourself without putting others down or asserting your superiority. Instead of comparing or competing against others, compare and compete against your ideal self.
- Don't allow yourself to get drawn into a power struggle. Imagine you're having a heated political debate with a friend, when he starts to call you "stupid" and "ignorant". When this happens, he's no longer trying to discuss politics, but to get you to submit. If you respond to his taunts, you'll only get drawn into a lose-lose situation.
 - If he "wins" the argument, you'll feel defeated. If he "loses" the argument, he'll feel slighted and seek revenge in the future. Either way, *your relationship is damaged*.
 - When you're facing a potential power struggle, *do not engage*. Choose to communicate through words and logic, not through anger.
- It is also not a weakness to admit to a fault or a mistake. Even if you think you're right, don't criticize the other person or say that he's wrong. This only shifts the focus to who's right or wrong to start a power struggle.



The goal of interpersonal relationships is to get a sense of community or belonging. This comes from being of use to others.

- In Adlerian psychology, this sense of community doesn't come from physical presence alone, e.g. being born into a

KEY QUOTES

"Life is not a competition."

"Happiness is the feeling of contribution."

"It's enough to just keep moving in a forward direction, without competing with anyone."

"It's only when we take away the lenses of competition and winning and losing that we can begin to correct and change ourselves."

"A sense of belonging is something that one acquires through one's own efforts—it is not something one is endowed with at birth."

family. You must actively contribute to the community by fulfilling your life tasks. Instead of focusing on what others can do for you, focus on what you can do for others.

- The Adlerian definition of “community” is extremely broad. It includes your family, friends, social/professional groups, society at large, humankind, and everything in the universe—from the past to the future, from living things to inanimate objects. All of us have multiple communities.
 - (i) Even if you’re not married and have no job/friends, you’re still a part of humanity and have an impact on others. For example, when you buy a meal, the money gets circulated into the economy to affect other people. You also consume resources that impacts the wider community and eco-system.
 - (ii) Anyone can have existential value, e.g. a newborn brings joy to her parents just by existing, even if she’s not actively “doing” something to contribute.



To get the sense of community, you must shift from self interest to social interest, which requires 3 things:

- Self-acceptance: Accept yourself as you are, complete with your flaws and imperfections. Only then can you identify what you can do and how you can improve.
 - (i) For example, if you’re only performing at 50%, acknowledge that fact and ask “How can I get closer to 100%?” What can you do with the skills, strengths, and resources at your disposal?
 - (ii) This is better than pretending that you’re already at 100%, blaming your poor performance on bad luck, or wishing for things you cannot change.
- Confidence in others: Believe in other people’s inherent potential and goodwill. Instead of waiting for people to “earn” your trust, show unconditional confidence in their good intent or potential.
 - (i) This helps to build deep relationships and encourage people to rise to their potential. For example, if someone deceives you, yet you’re willing to believe him unconditionally, he will probably find it hard to deceive you again.

KEY QUOTES

“When it comes down to it, all of us belong to the community of the earth, and the community of the universe.”

- (ii) However, this doesn't mean that you should naively trust everyone. It only applies to people with whom you wish to build a better or deeper relationship with. If someone repeatedly deceives you, then it's your task to decide whether to cut the ties.
- (iii) By contrast, relationships built on doubt and suspicion can never be strong or healthy. No matter what they say/do, you can always interpret it negatively to confirm your suspicions.
- Contribution to others: Once you accept yourself and have unconditional confidence in others, you'll naturally see people as comrades and want to contribute to their welfare. In the process, you feel happy because of the innate sense of existential worth, which further reinforces your self-acceptance in a virtuous cycle. You feel assured of your value even if your contributions aren't explicitly seen or recognized by others.
 - (i) Contribution to others is simply about being of use to others. It does *not* require self-sacrifice, which could be a sign that you're conforming too much to social expectations.
 - (ii) One of the most common ways to contribute is through work or labor. This can include anything from raising your children to performing acts of kindness for strangers.

 To improve your happiness and well-being, build "horizontal relationships" based on equality and respect.

- This is about seeing others as different but equal.
 - (i) Respect individual differences (e.g. gender, race, religion, values, life experiences) without seeing them as superior or inferior to you.
 - (ii) Recognize different types of contribution, e.g. a working husband contributes income to the family, whereas a stay-home mum cares for the home and kids. Neither is superior to the other.
- This is different from hierarchical or vertical relationships, where one party is seen as inherently superior to the other.

"It is through labor that one makes contributions to others and commits to one's community."

"Human beings are all equal, but not the same."

- (i) When you criticize or praise someone, it suggests that you're in a superior position to judge whether he/she is doing something right/well.
- (ii) When you interfere with someone's task, you're acting from a vertical relationship to assume you know what's good for the other person.
- It is much better to offer encouragement, i.e. to give people the courage to take on their life tasks. To do so, you can:
 - (i) Offer assistance without direct interference; and/or
 - (ii) Convey your gratitude. For example, when you say "Thank you, this was a great help to me" it tells the other person that they've made a valuable contribution without judging how "good" they are.
- In cases where a hierarchy is necessary (e.g. in organizational structures), you can still maintain equality in consciousness. For example, if you know that your boss's instructions are detrimental to a project, you can respectfully assert yourself instead of following orders blindly.

 In short, happiness isn't a goal in itself, but a by-product of a life well-lived—a life built on self-actualization and healthy relationships. According to Adler, life has no inherent meaning, and it's up to you to give meaning to life. You can choose to see the world as a terrible place full of enemies, or you can choose to see it as a wondrous place full of comrades.

- It's ok if you don't know what to do yet. So long as you contribute to others and live each moment to the fullest, you'll eventually find meaning and happiness in life. Keep asking yourself "What can I do now?" or "What can I do from now on?" Reject all excuses that lead you to avoid your life tasks.
- Just take the first step regardless of what others do or don't do. As you change, the world will seem to change too. That's because (i) you will start to see things differently, and (ii) people will start to respond to you differently.

"What is important is to be equal in consciousness, and to assert that which needs to be asserted."

"You can assign meaning to that life. And you are the only one who can assign meaning to your life."

"Do not look at the past, and do not look at the future. One lives each complete moment like a dance...As long as you are dancing, you will get somewhere."